

Why Get Involved? Reasons for Voluntary-Association Activity Among Americans and Canadians

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Using national representative sample survey data from the United States and Canada, the authors compare American and Canadian responses to a set of 14 possible reasons for being active in voluntary associations. They assess the 14 reasons individually and then conduct analyses in which the 14 measures are grouped into two composite scales: collective reasons and self-oriented motivations. The authors also consider theories for explaining how and why Americans and Canadians might differ in their motivations for volunteering. Analyses are conducted on seven background predictors: gender, race, religious affiliation, religious attendance, age, education, and socioeconomic status. Findings show that Americans are more likely than Canadians to mention altruistic rather than personal reasons for joining voluntary organizations, and Canadians are slightly more likely than Americans to emphasize personal reasons for their volunteer work, but this difference is not significant after controls. The implications of the findings for understanding voluntary activity in the two nations are discussed.

Keywords: *voluntary associations; reasons; Americans; Canadians*

A number of studies based on representative sample survey data have compared American levels of voluntary association activity with those found in Canada and a range of other nations (Curtis, 1971; Curtis, Baer, & Grabb, 2001; Curtis, Grabb, & Baer, 1992; Hallenstvedt, 1974; Hodgkinson, 2003; Inglehart,

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2003). Additional research has focused exclusively on the American/Canadian comparison (see, e.g., Curtis & Grabb, 2002; Curtis, Lambert, Brown, & Kay, 1989a, 1989b; Grabb & Curtis, 1992, 2005, chap. 11). The results of these studies generally show that the differences in association activity between Americans and Canadians (as well as differences involving the Dutch, the Swedes, and others) are small. Indeed, in a number of these comparisons, the differences are not statistically significant. The latter outcomes are most common when religious organizations are excluded from the count of membership types (Curtis et al., 1992; Curtis et al., 2001). Such findings are consistent with the view that there is a much greater emphasis on and commitment to religion and religious activity in the United States than in Canada and other Western societies. This higher level of religious involvement in the United States has been documented in numerous studies over the years (see, e.g., Bibby, 1987, 1993, 2002; Lipset, 1963, pp. 147-150; 1996, p. 19, p. 62; Ray, 2003; Reimer, 1995; Verba, Schlozman, & Brady, 1995; Watt, 1991, pp. 257-267).

HYPOTHESES ABOUT THE REASONS FOR VOLUNTEERING

Although considerable research has been conducted comparing the levels of voluntary-association membership of Americans and Canadians, to our knowledge, no research has yet considered another important question: Do those Americans and Canadians who actively participate in voluntary associations get involved for the same or different reasons? At one level of reasoning, we might expect that American and Canadian motivations for doing volunteer work would be very much alike because of the similar overall levels of voluntary activity in the two nations. Another consideration concerns the numerous social-structural and cultural similarities shared by the two societies. For example, both nations have enjoyed high levels of economic development and living standards, have had a long experience with stable and democratic political institutions, and comprise populations that evince a diverse mixture of Protestant and other Christian religious affiliations. Each of these characteristics has been shown to be a significant predictor of high levels of voluntary activity and to have been important for promoting voluntarism in the United States, Canada, and elsewhere (see, e.g., Curtis et al., 2001). It seems likely that these and other shared characteristics of the two nations should have helped to shape American and Canadian orientations to volunteer activity in similar ways.

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Nevertheless, there are also some clear social-structural divergences between the societies that could promote distinctly American and distinctly Canadian reasons for volunteering. A primary divergence is that Canada, although it is a liberal democracy similar to the United States, is nonetheless relatively more social democratic or "statist," with a more substantial social-welfare system and more extensive government-funded programs to aid the poor, the unemployed, and various other underprivileged or needy groups (see, e.g., Grabb & Curtis, 2005, pp. 168-171; Janoski, 1998, p. 23; Lipset, 1990, pp. 8, 130-134; Olsen, 2002, pp. 35-41). On this basis, one would hypothesize that, among Canadians, there is a lesser perceived need to do volunteer work that helps other citizens because the government more adequately fulfills this requirement. As a result, those Canadians who choose to join voluntary associations may be more apt than Americans to do so for other than altruistic reasons and more liable to volunteer for personal or self-oriented purposes. In contrast, Americans, because of the smaller role of their government in assisting individuals or in ensuring the public good, may be more prone than Canadians to see volunteer work as a central means for achieving civic-minded goals or altruistic ends in their communities. The pattern in previous research, which shows a greater tendency for Americans to participate in religious organizations, also suggests that one altruistic reason, religious beliefs, should be a more significant motivator for voluntary activity in the United States than in Canada.

The previous literature on reasons for volunteering in the United States provides us with further working hypotheses. Studies indicate that a mixture of incentives is often at work and that the same person may engage in civic participation due to both altruistic and personal considerations (see, e.g., Knoke, 1986, pp. 5-7; Smith, 1981, 1994, pp. 251-252; Wilson, 2000, pp. 218-219; Wilson & Musick, 1997, p. 256). Nevertheless, several studies of the reasons why Americans engage in volunteer work or join voluntary organizations have shown that altruistic reasons are usually among the main factors. For example, using data from a national survey conducted in 1992, Clary and colleagues found that individuals rated altruistic factors as the most important function of voluntary activity, ranking ahead of such self-oriented motivations as personal development, social rewards, learning, or career enhancement (Clary, Snyder, & Stukas, 1996, pp. 495-496, 487). This research also suggests that altruistic reasons, such as a desire to help others, to do something for an important cause, or to show compassion for people in need, are apt to be especially important for certain types of voluntary associations, including those that are connected to health services, religion, human services, and the environment (see also Clary et al., 1998, pp. 1517-1518; Clary & Miller, 1986; Clary & Orenstein, 1991; Smith, 1981, 1994, pp. 251, 258n; Wuthnow, 1991).

Although no directly comparable analyses have been conducted in Canada, some pertinent results are available from Statistics Canada's National Survey of Giving, Volunteering, and Participating (NSGVP). This survey showed that, in both 1997 and 2000, an altruistic factor, that is, believing in an

organization's cause, ranked as the most important reason for volunteering in Canada, although self-oriented factors, such as using one's skills and exploring one's strengths, also ranked as relatively important (Hall, McKeown, & Roberts, 2001, p. 43). One other study (Reed & Selbee, 2003), based on national survey data from 1997, compared the ratings of Canadian volunteers and nonvolunteers for a general list of 92 values, perceptions, and beliefs. The analysis showed that the responses of all volunteers differed little from those of nonvolunteers. However, the responses of genuinely active volunteers (those who did volunteer work once a week or more) were significantly more likely to reflect "other-directed" values, including beliefs about the importance of caring for people in the community and having a feeling of responsibility to help the needy in society (Reed & Selbee, 2003, pp. 100-102). Hence, these findings are consistent with the results from American studies because they suggest that volunteers, or at least those who are truly active, have a stronger sense of altruism than do other Canadians.

We would expect from these studies that altruistic factors would be more prominent than self-oriented factors as reasons for volunteering in both countries, regardless of whether altruistic reasons receive greater endorsement among Americans. These are our additional working hypotheses.

The American and Canadian waves of the World Values Surveys (WVS) from the early 1990s include a series of questions that were asked in both countries and that allow respondents to indicate their main reasons for being actively involved in voluntary organizations. In this article, we use these data to determine whether and to what extent Americans and Canadians differ in their motivations for working in voluntary associations. We turn now to a discussion of the data source and the methodological procedures employed in the analysis.

DATA AND METHODS

Our data come from the World Values Surveys of 1991-1993, a set of international surveys conducted by Ronald Inglehart and associates, involving more than 40 countries. In each country, a nationally representative sample was interviewed, using essentially the same questionnaire (Inglehart, 1997, Appendix 1).¹ The present analysis focuses solely on the American and Canadian components of the survey. The samples were weighted to make them representative of the two populations. Only respondents who were 18 years of age or older at the time of the interview were included. The analysis also excludes individuals who were not actively involved in doing work with at least one voluntary association because only these respondents were asked about possible motivations for volunteering. As a result, 907 (45.6%) of the total sample of 1,989 Americans and 739 (42.8%) of the total sample of 1,729 Canadians are included in the present analysis.²

To measure reasons for volunteering, respondents were instructed as follows: "Thinking about your reasons for doing voluntary work, please use the following scale to indicate how important each of the reasons below have been in your own case." Respondents were then given a card showing a scale ranging from 1 (*unimportant*) to 5 (*very important*) and were asked to rate each of 14 reasons for engaging in voluntary activity. The reasons were as follows: (1) "a sense of solidarity with the poor and disadvantaged"; (2) "compassion for those in need"; (3) "an opportunity to repay something, give something back"; (4) "a sense of duty, moral obligation"; (5) "identifying with people who were suffering"; (6) "time on my hands, wanted something worthwhile to do"; (7) "purely for personal satisfaction"; (8) "religious beliefs"; (9) "to help give disadvantaged people hope and dignity"; (10) "to make a contribution to my local community"; (11) "to bring about social and political change"; (12) "for social reasons, to meet people;" (13) "to gain new skills and useful experience"; and (14) "I did not want to but could not refuse."

In part because previous research has uncovered evidence of multiple dimensions represented within inventories of possible motivations for volunteering (see especially Clary et al., 1996; Clary et al., 1998), we conducted a series of factor analyses of the 14 items used in the WVS. Here, we sought to determine if a similar factor structure, with much the same set of dimensions, would emerge from the combined data for the two countries. We used various rotation techniques and tested for the existence of distinct factors. The final results reported here are based on a maximum-likelihood extraction with oblique rotation and Kaiser normalization, which allows the extracted factors to be intercorrelated. In contrast to previous American research (Clary et al., 1996; Clary et al., 1998), we uncovered just two identifiable dimensions. This discrepancy between our factor-analytic results and those found by other researchers is probably due to several divergences between our measures and those employed in other studies. In particular, the 14 items from the WVS are worded differently, are less numerous, and are less wide-ranging. For these reasons, the simpler factor structure revealed in our analysis is probably not surprising.

The first of the two factors incorporates nine of the items, including those numbered 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 8, 9, 10, and 11. This is clearly an altruism measure, as evidenced by the content of the items that load most highly on this factor. For example, the top four of these items include "to help give disadvantaged people hope and dignity" (.779), "identifying with people who were suffering" (.762), "compassion for those in need" (.711), and "a sense of solidarity with the poor and disadvantaged" (.687). We treat the altruism measure as a summated scale (while inserting mean scores for the few nonresponses that occurred with each individual item). The scale shows a high level of internal consistency reliability, with a standardized item alpha of .80.

The second identifiable dimension emerging from the factor analysis comprises the remaining five items: 6, 7, 12, 13, and 14. This dimension is less

determinate, and the summated scale is less reliable, with a standardized item alpha of .69. However, this factor has sufficient internal consistency for our purposes in the present analysis. This measure is also a useful counterpoint to the first scale because it appears to capture an underlying dimension that, although not the complete opposite of the altruism scale, is clearly distinct from it. This seems evident from the content of the items that load most highly on this second scale, namely, "for social reasons, to meet people" (.678), followed by "to gain new skills and useful experience" (.547), "time on my hands, wanted something worthwhile to do" (.416), and "purely for personal satisfaction" (.384). Although this factor does not comprise completely selfish motivations, it captures a more self-oriented, or what we have labeled a "personal," set of rationales for doing voluntary work.³

The altruism and personal-reasons scales are positively and significantly correlated with each other ($r = +.323, p < .001$), which shows that those respondents who rate altruistic reasons for volunteering as important also tend to rate personal motivations as important. This finding is thus consistent with previous studies that, as noted earlier, show that people who volunteer may indeed be motivated by a mixture of both altruistic and self-oriented reasons at the same time (Knoke, 1986, pp. 5-7; Smith, 1994, pp. 251-252).

We begin our analysis with a bivariate comparison of how Americans and Canadians rate each of the 14 reasons considered individually and also their scores on the two composite scales. In addition, we look at national differences with the religious beliefs item removed from the altruism scale. This is to determine if any differences that we may find between Americans and Canadians regarding their altruistic reasons for volunteering are primarily attributable to the relatively greater emphasis on religion in the United States.

Next, we consider multivariate patterns. For reasons of parsimony and to conserve space, here we focus only on the two scales as our dependent measures and do not look at the individual component items, although we do consider the altruism scale both with and without the religious beliefs measure included. The central purpose of the multivariate analysis is to assess whether controlling for the effects of seven key social-background predictors may partly or completely account for any American/Canadian differences in people's ratings of altruistic and personal reasons for doing voluntary work. These seven predictors are as follows: gender (with men coded as 1 and women treated as the reference category and coded as 0), race (White = 1, non-White = 0), religious affiliation (Protestant = 1, all others = 0), religious attendance (on an 8-point ordinal scale from 1 = *lowest* to 8 = *highest*), age in years, education (as measured by age at completion of schooling, which involved a 10-point scale from 1 = age 12 to 10 = age 21 or higher), and socioeconomic status (as judged by the interviewers' ratings, on a 4-point scale from 1 = *lowest* to 4 = *highest*).

These seven variables have been shown in previous research to be related to levels of voluntary activity. Although there are some exceptions, particularly for race, the typical pattern in these studies has been for people with relatively

more dominant, more central, or more privileged social statuses to exhibit higher levels of voluntarism and civic participation (see, e.g., Curtis et al., 1992; Curtis et al., 2001; Curtis, Grabb, Perks, & Chui, 2004; Grabb & Curtis, 1992; Knoke, 1986; Lemon, Palisi, & Jacobsen, 1972; Milbrath & Goel, 1977; Musick, Wilson, & Bynum, 2000; Smith, 1975, 1994; Wilson, 2000; Wilson & Janoski, 1995; Wilson & Musick, 1997). Although relevant research literature is sparse, there is also reason to believe that at least some of these variables may be related to motivations for volunteering. In particular, Clary et al. (1996, pp. 497-501) found a tendency for some less privileged groups—mainly women and Blacks—to mention both altruistic and nonaltruistic reasons for volunteering to a greater extent than their more dominant or privileged counterparts. On the other hand, for predictors such as income and education, their research revealed no clear and consistent pattern.⁴

RESULTS

BIVARIATE FINDINGS

In Table 1, the two national samples are compared with respect to their ratings of how important each of the 14 reasons is for volunteering. This table also shows how the American and Canadian respondents compare on the altruism and personal-reasons scales.

The first point to note is that the two samples generally reveal highly similar rankings of the 14 individual reasons for volunteering. For example, despite some slight differences in the internal rankings of the top five reasons, as a group, the leading five motivations are the same in both samples. These reasons, each of which is altruistic in nature, include compassion for the needy, a desire to repay or give something back, a sense of moral duty or obligation, contributing to the local community, and helping the disadvantaged have hope and dignity. Similarly, the three least important reasons given by Americans and Canadians are the same, and in this case are ranked in the identical order. All of these are personal in nature and include not wanting to volunteer but being unable to refuse, for social reasons or to meet people, and because of having time on their hands.

In fact, the only sizeable difference in the rankings for the two samples is that religious beliefs is a more important reason for volunteering among American respondents, who rate this as 6th out of the 14 possible reasons, compared with a rating of 10th out of 14 in the Canadian sample. The gap between the American and Canadian scores for the religious beliefs item is also much larger (3.70 vs. 3.04 on a 5-point scale) than the gap for any of the other 14 items. These results are consistent with the prediction, based on the higher levels of religious involvement in the United States, that religious beliefs will be of greater salience for explaining volunteering among Americans than among Canadians.

Table 1. American and Canadian Scores on the 14 Individual Reasons for Volunteering, and on the Altruism Scale, the Altruism Scale Excluding Religious Beliefs, and the Personal-Reasons Scale, Using Data From the 1990s World Values Surveys

Reason	Total		Americans		Canadians		Significance
	Score	Rank	Score	Rank	Score	Rank	
1. Compassion for the needy	3.99	1	4.07	1	3.90	1	**
2. To repay give back something	3.93	2	3.98	2	3.87	2	*
3. Contribute to local community	3.88	3	3.92	4	3.83	3	ns
4. Sense of duty, moral obligation	3.87	4	3.95	3	3.77	4	***
5. To give hope, dignity to disadvantaged	3.76	5	3.83	5	3.68	5	**
6. Identify with those who are suffering	3.61	6	3.66	7	3.55	6	ns
7. Religious beliefs	3.40	7	3.70	6	3.04	10	***
8. Solidarity with poor, disadvantaged	3.34	8	3.34	8	3.35	8	ns
9. To gain skills, experience	3.24	9	3.13	11	3.38	7	***
10. Purely for personal satisfaction	3.20	10	3.19	10	3.21	9	ns
11. To bring social, political change	3.07	11	3.13	9	3.00	11	*
12. Time on my hands	2.81	12	2.78	12	2.86	12	*
13. Social reasons, to meet people	2.70	13	2.62	13	2.80	13	**
14. Did not want to, couldn't refuse	1.99	14	2.02	14	1.96	14	ns
Altruism Scale	32.86	—	33.58	—	32.00	—	***
Altruism Scale, excluding religious beliefs	29.46	—	29.88	—	28.96	—	**
Personal-reasons scale	13.95	—	13.73	—	14.21	—	*

Note: Individual items are on 5-point scales where 1 = *unimportant*, 5 = *very important*. The maximum possible score on the Altruism scale is 45. The maximum possible score on the Altruism scale, excluding religious beliefs, is 40. The maximum possible score on the personal-reasons scale is 25. Significance refers to whether the differences between the American and Canadian scores are statistically significant. ns = not significant.

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

Table 2. Unstandardized Multiple Regression Analysis Showing National Differences on the Altruism Scale, the Altruism Scale Excluding Religious Beliefs, and the Personal-Reasons Scale, With Controls for Seven Background Variables

	<i>Altruism Scale</i>	<i>Altruism Scale (Excluding Religious Beliefs)</i>	<i>Personal- Reasons Scale</i>
Intercept	35.17	32.50	18.69
Predictor			
Nation (USA = 1, Canada = 0)	1.07**	0.66*	-0.15
Gender (male = 1, female = 0)	-0.27	-0.30	0.38
Race (White = 1, non-White = 0)	-2.05***	-1.64**	0.20
Religion (Protestant = 1, others = 0)	-0.04	-0.14	-0.68**
Religious attendance	0.61***	0.31***	0.11*
Age	0.01	0.01	-0.03***
Education	-0.32***	-0.26**	-0.35***
Socioeconomic status	-0.77***	-0.60**	-0.51***
Adjusted R ²	10.9%	5.2%	6.0%

* $p < .05$. ** $p < .01$. *** $p < .001$.

There are some other differences between the American and Canadian rankings. Specifically, although both samples give altruistic reasons the highest priority, there is a greater tendency for American respondents than for Canadian respondents to do so. As shown in Table 1, this is evident in the statistically significant differences found for six of the nine individual altruism items, and also for the overall altruism scale. In the case of the altruism scale, the American score is 33.58 (out of a possible 45), compared with 32.00 for the Canadians, and the difference between these scores, although not large, is statistically significant ($p < .001$). As we would expect, the national difference becomes noticeably smaller if the religious beliefs item is removed from the count of altruistic reasons. Then, the difference between Americans and Canadians is less than 1 point on a 40-point scale, although this difference is still statistically significant ($p < .01$). Finally, we see a weak but significant tendency for Canadians to rate personal factors for volunteering more highly than do Americans. This is true for the item dealing with social reasons and meeting people, the item asking about acquiring skills and experience, the question about having time on one's hands, and the overall personal-reasons scale. In the latter instance, the Canadian score is 14.21 (out of a possible 25), compared with an American score of 13.73 ($p < .05$).

In general, then, these bivariate patterns support the conclusion that it is Americans rather than Canadians who are more apt to be motivated by altruistic factors in their choice to be actively involved in voluntary associations. For Canadians, on the other hand, there is at least some modest indication that they find personal factors, especially meeting other people and acquiring skills and experience, as relatively more important than do Americans.

MULTIVARIATE ANALYSIS

Altruism. Table 2 presents an ordinary least squares multiple regression analysis, in which the American and Canadian respondents are compared on the altruism scale, both with and without religious beliefs included, and on the personal-reasons scale. Each analysis also assesses the possible effects of the seven background predictors. The findings indicate that, even with controls, Americans are more likely than Canadians to rate altruistic reasons for volunteering as important. With controls, the American/Canadian difference on the 45-point scale is 1.07 ($p < .01$). The difference reduces to about .66 if the religious beliefs item is excluded, but it is still statistically significant ($p < .05$).

As for the effects on altruism of the other predictors, we find no gender difference, no age effect, and no difference between Protestants and other religious faiths. However, regular attendance at religious services, whatever the faith, is positively related to altruism, and this is true even when the religious beliefs item is not included in the altruism scale. One of the most interesting results in Table 2 is the pattern for race, which indicates that non-Whites are significantly and substantially more likely than Whites to volunteer for altruistic reasons. Here, the difference is more than two points overall ($b = -2.05, p < .001$), and more than one and a half points ($b = -1.65, p < .01$) when the religious beliefs item is excluded from the count of altruistic motivations. Thus, it is noteworthy that non-Whites, who are generally acknowledged to be among the least privileged and least empowered individuals in either country, are relatively more likely than the other respondents in the two national samples to focus their volunteer efforts on helping the less fortunate and the less powerful in their societies.

In a somewhat similar fashion, we see, as well, that socioeconomic status and educational attainment are negatively related to altruism. In other words, it is those volunteers who come from the less advantaged socioeconomic and educational strata who are the most likely to say that they volunteer for reasons such as giving back to the community or assisting those in need. These outcomes call into question the notion that the more educated and more prosperous classes in countries such as the United States and Canada are more likely than other people to be motivated by altruistic considerations when engaging in voluntary-association activity (for some discussion, see, e.g., Curtis et al., 2004).

The personal-reasons scale. Turning to the personal-reasons scale, we see that the slight tendency, found in Table 1, for Canadians to place a greater importance than Americans on personal reasons for voluntary activity does not stand up with controls on the effects of the other predictors. This change appears to stem primarily from the fact that, compared with the Canadian respondents, Americans are significantly more likely to be Protestants, to be older, to be higher in socioeconomic status, and to have higher levels of education (data not shown in tables). As we can see in Table 2, each of these four

factors is associated with placing a lower level of importance on personal reasons for volunteering. Consequently, when we take the effects of these predictors into account, the American/Canadian difference on the personal-reasons scale becomes statistically insignificant.

Some of the results for the personal-reasons scale may be surprising. Consider, for example, that those who report the highest levels of attendance at religious services are actually somewhat more likely, not less likely, than other people to say that they volunteer for personal or self-oriented reasons. This could be puzzling if we expect that individuals who are more involved in religion are more apt than other people to be selfless or other-directed in their daily lives and, therefore, more motivated by these considerations when they participate in community activities. Indeed, this expectation conforms with our previous finding that religious attendance is positively related to the altruism scale. Parallel results occur with both education and socioeconomic status; that is, although, as we have already shown, less-educated people and those with lower socioeconomic status are more likely than others to say that they volunteer for altruistic reasons, we see here that these individuals are also more likely to say that they volunteer for personal reasons. Again, however, if we recall that the altruism scale and the personal-reasons scale are positively correlated, then these results for religious attendance, education, and socioeconomic status are not paradoxical. They indicate that those people who volunteer for the first kind of reason have a tendency to volunteer for the second kind of reason as well. The two broad types of reasons for association involvement are not mutually exclusive.⁵

DISCUSSION AND CONCLUSIONS

In this analysis, we have considered whether Americans and Canadians who are actively involved with voluntary associations differ in their reasons for doing volunteer work. Although existing research has shown that the two peoples are generally similar in their levels of voluntary-organization membership, until now, no research has been conducted to determine if this national similarity extends to Canadian and American reasons for engaging in voluntary activity. In fact, the comparative literature offers a basis for predicting that American and Canadian reasons for volunteering will not be quite the same. We have considered the hypothesis that American volunteers are more likely than their Canadian counterparts to be moved by altruistic considerations, in part because Americans live in a less statist society. As a result of the latter difference, Americans could feel a greater obligation than Canadians to apply their volunteer efforts selflessly, assisting individuals and groups who cannot rely on government agencies or public-sector initiatives to fulfill these important needs. Another comparative social-structural difference is that Americans are generally more highly involved in religious activities than are

Canadians and most other peoples. This difference, too, we hypothesized, may be an important influence promoting greater altruistic volunteering among Americans.

Our findings indicate that, for the most part, Americans and Canadians stress similar sets of reasons for doing volunteer work. Both populations tend to rank a list of 14 different motivations for volunteering in broadly parallel ways, with collective or “altruistic” considerations being the most important factors and self-oriented or “personal” reasons having a lower priority in each nation. However, where Americans and Canadians *do* differ, the patterns of results support our working hypothesis. In other words, Americans place more emphasis than Canadians on six of nine altruistic motivations for volunteering, with higher average scores on compassion for the needy, giving back to others, a sense of moral obligation, a desire to help the disadvantaged, to bring social or political change, and especially religious beliefs. The American/Canadian differences on these six questions are not large, except for the religious beliefs item, but they are statistically significant. Moreover, when we analyze the data using a composite scale of the nine altruism measures, the national difference is sustained, even with controls for the possible confounding effects of seven other predictor variables. That is, the higher level of altruism expressed by Americans is not attributable to national variations in gender distribution, racial composition, religious affiliation, frequency of attendance at religious services, age distribution, educational attainment, or socioeconomic status. We also find, as expected, that removing religious beliefs from the scale of altruistic motivations substantially reduces the American/Canadian difference, although it does not eliminate it. Religious issues provide stronger motives for community and social activities in the United States than they do in Canada.

In addition to assessing national divergences in the altruism of volunteers, we also have considered whether Americans and Canadians differ with respect to the importance that they attach to personal reasons for voluntarism. Here, the data provide only limited evidence of national differences. We have found that Canadians are slightly more likely than Americans to point to personal reasons when asked about why they do volunteer work. This pattern is evident for the overall scale and for three of five personal motivations—to gain skills and experience, for social reasons, and because of having time on one’s hands. However, the differences do not hold after controls. These results indicate that the American/Canadian difference in regard to personal motivations operates through some of the control variables. That is to say, it is because Canadians are, on average, less likely to be Protestants, are lower in education, and are lower in socioeconomic status that they stress personal reasons for volunteering more than do Americans. These findings do not negate the national difference before controls, but they do clarify its causes.

We turn now to the main effects of the seven predictors that were used as control variables in the present study. Most notable here are the effects for education, socioeconomic status, and race. In the case of education and

socioeconomic status, previous research has consistently shown that people with relatively high levels of educational attainment and socioeconomic status are the most likely to join and be active in voluntary associations. What our analysis indicates, however, is that the reasons why such individuals engage in volunteer work are less likely to be altruistic than are the motivations of other, less privileged volunteers. In other words, in those instances where poorer and less-educated people are able to volunteer, it is these Americans and Canadians who are more apt to be moved by compassion and a desire to assist their fellow citizens. Although less advantaged volunteers may have less in the way of social resources or "social capital" than others have, our research suggests that they are also more likely to apply whatever resources they do possess to the general welfare and the public good by helping those in need, giving hope and dignity to other disadvantaged people, and otherwise giving back to their communities.

Because of the tendency for volunteers from the lower educational and socioeconomic strata to rank higher than other volunteers on our altruism scale, it may seem surprising that they rank higher on the personal-reasons measure as well. However, it is clear that these two outcomes need not be contradictory because it is conceivable that people who volunteer out of a desire to help others also can be motivated to help themselves in the process. Our finding that the two scales used in this analysis are positively intercorrelated is consistent with this interpretation. Thus, especially in the case of poorer and less-educated volunteers, who, as noted above, lack the social capital and related advantages enjoyed by others, volunteering is a potentially important means for making contacts, acquiring skills, and gaining experience, all of which could prove useful for personal betterment or advancement. Those volunteers who have higher education and socioeconomic status, on the other hand, would presumably have sufficient advantages in social connections and social capital that they would have a lesser need or desire to volunteer for these more self-oriented reasons.

This brings us to the findings involving race. Here it may be tempting to draw conclusions that are similar to those that we have made with respect to education and socioeconomic status because, in this case as well, the results show that it is the relatively less privileged or powerful individuals, that is, non-Whites as opposed to Whites, who are more likely to emphasize altruistic factors as their reasons for doing work with voluntary organizations. However, there are some differences that suggest the patterns for race may not be quite the same as for education or socioeconomic status. To begin with, unlike the lower educational and socioeconomic strata, it is not clear from previous American research that non-Whites, despite also being a relatively less "central" or less "dominant" group, exhibit lower levels of voluntary-association involvement than Whites, at least if education, socioeconomic status, and related factors such as income are statistically controlled (recall, e.g., Knoke, 1986; Smith, 1975, 1994; Wilson, 2000). Second, although our results show that, similar to the less educated and those from the lower socioeconomic strata,

non-Whites rank altruistic motives relatively highly, we have found, unlike the other two social groupings, that non-Whites do not tend to rank personal reasons for volunteering more highly than do other respondents. The latter pattern is not wholly consistent with previous research by Clary et al. (1996), who found that non-Whites were more likely than Whites to be motivated by altruistic and by nonaltruistic motivations when engaging in volunteer activity. Here again, we can only speculate about explanations for our results, but they may indicate that, net of any socioeconomic, educational, religious, or other considerations, non-Whites simply have a stronger sense of and experience with the unmet needs of the people in their communities. As a result, non-Whites in both nations would feel a greater desire or obligation than other people to put a high priority on trying to achieve altruistic ends through their volunteer work. It is important that this interpretation, along with explanations for the education and socioeconomic-status effects, be tested more fully with future research.

Certainly, the patterns of reasons for volunteering by race are common across the two national samples, as are the patterns of effects for the other social-background factors. Also, as we have shown, the factor structures for the reasons to volunteer, as well as the rates of volunteering, are very much alike in the two countries. Taken together, these results strongly suggest similar dynamics for the organization of volunteer work in the United States and Canada. This makes it even more interesting that we have found evidence of a national difference in the level of altruistic volunteering. Although these differences are small, they are in the direction that we would predict based on the differing roles of the state and religion in the United States and Canada. Moreover, they are sustained even with controls for the effects of other predictors. It appears that the dominant ideologies associated with government and with religion create somewhat different commitments to altruism in the two nations. Generally, our findings concerning American and Canadian reasons for voluntary activity are consistent with a large body of comparative research that shows that the two peoples have many fundamental behavioral and attitudinal similarities, as well as certain subtle and yet important differences (see, e.g., Grabb & Curtis, 2005; Lipset, 1990, 1996).

Notes

1. Although samples from the United States and Canada were studied in other waves of the World Values Surveys (WVS), that is, those conducted in the early 1980s and in 1999-2001, neither of these waves includes questions on people's reasons for joining voluntary organizations. Therefore, the WVS data from the early 1990s provide the only opportunity in recent decades to do the kind of comparative analysis presented here.

2. The national difference in the proportion of individuals who actively work for at least one voluntary association is not statistically significant. Analyses also show that the proportion who work for at least two voluntary associations are essentially the same, at 23.1% for Americans and 22.5% for Canadians. Respondents were asked about their participation in 16 different types of

associations. The American and Canadian patterns with respect to the types of associations that people join were quite similar. The only substantial difference, as expected, is that Americans are about twice as likely as Canadians to be active in religious organizations (28% vs. 15%), although, even here, Canadians, similar to Americans, are more active in religious organizations than in any other types of association. Americans are less likely than Canadians to be active in sports or recreation organizations (8% vs. 12%) but are more likely to be active in youth groups (9% vs. 7%). For the remaining types of organizations, national differences were very small (usually less than 1%) and typically were not statistically significant.

3. We conducted parallel factor analyses for the American and Canadian respondents considered separately as a check for whether the factor structures were different in the two samples. These analyses revealed virtually the same patterns in both national groups. For example, the four items that loaded most highly on the altruism scale in the American sample also did so in the Canadian sample, and showed very similar scores. In the same way, the four items that loaded most highly on the personal-reasons scale in the United States did so in Canada as well, and also showed very similar scores.

4. One other reason for doing the controlled analyses is that the American and Canadian samples differ somewhat in the distribution of the seven background predictors. Compared with the Canadian sample, the American sample has proportionally more non-Whites and more Protestants. The American sample is also higher in religious attendance, younger, more highly educated, and higher on the measure of socioeconomic status. The two samples are not significantly different with respect to gender composition.

5. Separate analyses (not shown in the tables) reveal that all of the significant relationships between the predictor variables and the two scales are in the same direction in each national sample. We also conducted further multivariate analyses that are not presented here, in which we compared reasons for voluntary activity across four regional samples: the U.S. North, the U.S. South, English Canada, and Quebec. Respondents from both the North and the South are higher on altruism than the English-Canadian reference group, whereas Quebecers are not significantly different from English Canadians. On the personal-reasons scale, Quebecers are significantly higher than the other three groups, but these three groups do not differ significantly from each other.

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